

TEAM WORK Harsh Jain (left), Bhavit Sheth

Living the Dream

HARSH JAIN, 36, *CEO & Co-founder, Dream11*
BHAVIT SHETH, 36, *COO & Co-founder, Dream11*, **Mumbai**

An idea that had its seeds in a casual conversation between friends fresh out of college has today taken shape as one of India's largest fantasy gaming companies. Dream11, a pioneer in the fantasy gaming segment in India, was founded in 2008 by Harsh Jain and Bhavit Sheth. It started off as a personal project since the co-founders were big fans of English football fantasy leagues. Their big idea was to start something similar to the Indian Premier League (IPL) in gaming. While doing his MBA from Bentley University, Sheth, also an engineering graduate, would look at the way fantasy leagues are played in the US—in baseball, football and basketball. Co-founder Jain has done his engineering from the University of Pennsylvania and an MBA from Columbia Business School.

Competition has grown and there are at least 60 other gaming platforms operating in the same genre in India, according to news reports. But Dream11 stayed ahead. Users across Dream Sports platforms now number 140 million. The company commands a valuation of $8 billion (about Rs 60,400 crore). It has diversified to include sports technology products and services. It recently committed $50 million (Rs 380 crore) to in-house sports content and commerce platform FanCode. The firm has also introduced payment solutions through DreamPay, and launched a sports accelerator, DreamX. In 2020, Dream11 won the title sponsorship rights for the 2020 IPL for Rs 222 crore. ■

–*M.G. Arun*

"While starting a company, it is important to define its culture and then align everyone to that culture. Systems and processes may have to be reinvented but the culture will always be the same"

BHAVIT SHETH

FUNDS FUNDA Before getting their first funding from Kalaari Capital, Sheth and Jain had approached some 150 venture capitalists and private equity investors, but were refused by all of them